

CORDS and Pacification

As part of the overall war effort, the US created a number of programs to assist, pacify, and make allies of South Vietnam's civilian population, in particular rural villagers more inclined to favor, shelter, and even join the communist forces.

◀ BEFORE

The "hearts and minds" campaign developed out of earlier civilian pacification programs launched by US forces.

EARLY EFFORTS

The US first experimented with proactive pacification techniques during the Philippine–American War (1899–1902), trying to win over the populace by building schools and public works.

AFTER THE ACCORDS

In Vietnam, pacification kicked off shortly after Vietnam became independent and was split into **separate nations** in 1954. From the very start, the programs concentrated on a rural, peasant population long abused under French colonial rule and most likely to have political, social, and economic gripes about the South Vietnamese regime. Early programs ranged from amnesties for Viet Cong rebels to the construction of fortified **strategic hamlets** protected by government troops.

Pacification programs were designed to win over local people and lessen their desire to revolt. They encouraged them to live peaceably and cooperate with US and ARVN forces in spite of a turbulent situation. Early programs had not been especially effective, leading the US to devise new ways to win the "hearts and minds" of South Vietnam's rural population. Foremost among these was the Civil Operations and Revolutionary Development Support (CORDS) program created by US Ambassador Henry Cabot Lodge in 1967. Although it was technically a military program, White House Special Assistant Robert Komer was brought to Vietnam to head the program.

Setting priorities

Under Komer's leadership, CORDS integrated personnel from the military intelligence, Central Intelligence Agency (CIA), and a number of South Vietnamese agencies into teams that could gather and assess intelligence data, in cooperation with operatives and advisory teams in the field. The program was tasked with growing the People's Self-Defense Force militias in rural areas. The other major priority for CORDS in 1968 was the resettlement of displaced Montagnard tribespeople.

At the same time, the US Agency for International Development (USAID) made a push to bring modern health care into villages across South Vietnam. Their work ranged from efforts to eradicate malarial mosquitoes to staffing and equipping rural aid stations and provincial hospitals.